

PEOPLES OF ASIA II

ALTHOUGH SOME ASIAN COUNTRIES, such as Japan and China, have been independent for a long time, others have only recently emerged from colonization. At the start of the 20th century, much of the Middle East, the whole Indian Subcontinent, and large areas of Southeast Asia were controlled by European powers. Nationalist movements grew up across Asia and the countries regained their independence. Many countries here have had very fast economic growth. Together with the recent pressures for change, this means that societies across the region are now evolving rapidly.



The former USSR

This map shows the former USSR and the 15 republics that it divided up into.



BREAKUP

The Soviet Union, or USSR, was the world's largest nation. However, in 1991, the USSR split up into 15 republics, which set up their own governments. Nine of the republics are in Europe and the other five are in Asia, while Russia straddles both. They are no longer part of a large, centralized economy, and so are struggling to compete in a world market. The USSR's collapse also freed some eastern European countries from Soviet control.

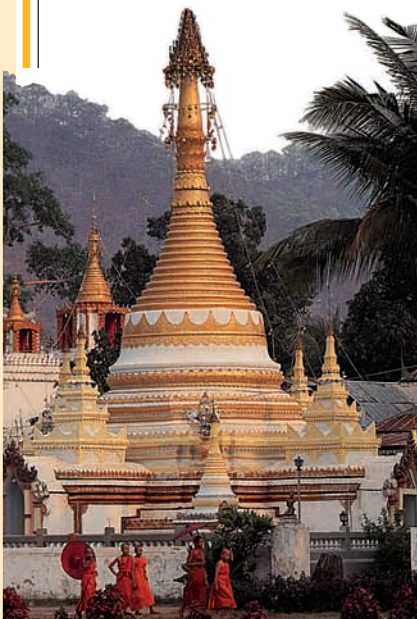


Chechnya's capital Grozny was heavily bombed by the Russian Federation in 1994–95 and again in 1999–2000.

WORLD RELIGIONS

Asia was the birthplace of all the main world religions, including Hinduism, Buddhism, Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. Religious beliefs still have a strong influence on the people of the region today. Religions often emphasize modesty in wealth and the importance of donating to charity for spiritual reward rather than any personal gain.

This temple is in Thailand, where Buddhism is the main religion.



Most young men in Thailand live in a monastery as monks for a few months.



INDEPENDENCE

Each year, many countries in the region celebrate their freedom from colonial rule in independence day celebrations, like those in Pakistan shown above. Some countries, like India, gained their independence through largely peaceful protest, while fierce fighting occurred in others, such as Indonesia. These countries are now struggling to forge a sense of national unity.

ETHNIC GROUPS

Fighting between ethnic groups is still continuing in several parts of the former USSR. The Russian Federation, for example, includes some regions where the Russian population is in the minority and greater numbers of people belong to native ethnic groups.

In Chechnya, only about a third of the population is Russian. Since the breakup of the USSR, the Chechens have been fighting for independence. However, the Russian Federation is not prepared to grant independence to any of these territories. It could lead to the breakup of Russia itself.

